BIHAR

SHOTGUN WEDDINGS

By Amitabh Srivastava



On May 30, Bhojpuri singer Nisha Updhyaya was in the middle of her performance at a social gathering in Bihar's Bhojpur district, when a gunshot fired by an exuberant reveller pierced her left leg. The singer collapsed on the stage.

A week in the hospital and Nisha has survived. She could count herself as a lucky exception, having survived a gunshot wound in a state where at least 25 persons have lost their lives just this year in reckless instances of celebratory firing. Two years ago, in Supaul district, a stray bullet lodged itself in the bride's leg—she too was lucky, if one grants that getting shot just before exchanging your wedding garlands can count as luck. At other times, brides themselves have been known to take a gun and let loose a volley, leading to colourful headlines like '*bandookbaaz dulhania*'. And tentwallahs are often chary of plying their trade in the more notorious villages: their shamianas invariably come back pock-marked with holes.

Neither Bihar nor the country itself suffers any dearth of hair-trigger situations that explode into violence for deep-seated social reasons—personal rivalry, caste animus or religious polarisation. But to have celebratory occasions, especially weddings, punctuated by the rattle of guns is a special bequest of the northern states. Exuberant revellers indulging in this edgy form of catharsis is a customary ritual across Bihar. Often, a bit too edgy—and a life is gone amidst the pageantry. Scan the news, and you find a case—or five or six—every month.

Look only at the month of May. Sonam, 18, died on May 29 at a marriage in Mircha village of Jamui district. The BA student, who aspired for nothing more than the security of a government job, was silenced when a bullet fired by an inebriated young man hit her head. On May 27, Bittu Singh, 25, was downed by a gunshot at the tilak ceremony of his cousin in Bhojpur district. On May 21, Shambhunath Singh alias Netaji, 55, fell to a bullet fired by a reveller from the groom's side at a marriage ceremony in Vaishali district. On May 17, teenager Aman Kumar died in Samastipur after a bullet fired in a local marriage procession fatally wounded him. On May 14, an 18-year-old dancer Chandani was shot dead at a tilak ceremony in Rohtas where she had gone to perform. On May 1, Rohit Singh, 20, died after being hit by a gunshot at his cousin's wedding at Saidpur in Bhojpur district.

An enduring symbol of feudal machismo, brandishing firearms, legal or otherwise, seems to afford a perverse blend of power and pleasure to people otherwise sunk in the mundane anonymity of mofussil life—in a society where violence can